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US attorney under fire again

Judge says Boutros violated order sealing Tren de Aragua gang case

By Jason Meisner
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

A contrite U.S. Attorney Andrew Boutros told a federal magistrate judge Thursday he was confident that a murder and kidnapping case involving the Tren de Aragua gang would have been unsealed by the time he appeared for a news conference last week with his bosses in Washington, D.C.

But, as with the old adage known

as Murphy's law, "the stars did not align," Boutros told U.S. Magistrate Judge Laura McNally.

Instead, Boutros found himself on a stage with acting Attorney General Todd Blanche and FBI Director Kash Patel on the morning of July 1 revealing details of a complaint — including names and photographs of two of the defendants — that McNally had ordered hidden from public view by request of Boutros' office, citing risk of flight

and potential danger to the community.

The way the episode unfolded, Boutros told McNally, was "very regrettable and very unfortunate, because like you I take very seriously the orders of the court. Always have and always will."

"I didn't ask for this press conference," he said. "I wasn't looking to go to D.C. I had a huge press confer-

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U.S. Attorney Andrew Boutros holds a press conference at the Dirksen U.S. Courthouse on July 2 to talk about a multi-agency crime fighting operation that was run in the region. **TERRENCE ANTONIO JAMES/TRIBUNE**



Federal officers use tear gas and smoke on members of the community and activists while they protest near the 3900 block of South Kedzie Avenue on Oct. 4, 2025, in Chicago. **ARMANDO L. SANCHEZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Lawsuits: Border Patrol used 'excessive, unprovoked' force

Advocates warn of immigration enforcement uptick in Brighton Park, Back of the Yards

By Allison Kiehl
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

For lawyer Brian Orozco, it's personal. When federal agents deployed tear gas at protesters in Brighton Park on Oct. 4, after they had shot a woman, the gas hit Orozco's face as he stood on a sidewalk. Orozco said it was like he couldn't breathe.

"My eyes were burning, but my lungs were burning more," Orozco said.

Now, he stands in community with five other families hit with tear gas and violence from

federal agents in Chicago during last fall's Operation Midway Blitz, representing them as they sue the federal agency for \$1 million each.

The lawsuits come as residents and immigration activists are sounding the alarm about heightened immigration enforcement activity in Chicago, particularly on the Southwest Side in Brighton Park and Back of the Yards. Orozco stood at a news conference Thursday afternoon in New City with local nonprofits who are spreading the word about the uptick in immigration arrests, which has brought back fear and trauma to

communities that bore the brunt of President Donald Trump's immigration enforcement operation last year.

"I identify with my clients: the pain, the fear, the frustration, the anger," Orozco said. He said he was lawfully observing a protest when he was tear-gassed. "We were helping to de-escalate peaceful protest, definitely weren't doing anything wrong. It was completely unprovoked, completely unnecessary."

The five new independent lawsuits were filed July 1 in the Northern District of Illinois

federal court, all represented by Orozco and Gregory E. Kulis & Associates. The suits speak of tear-gassing and other confrontations during the height of Operation Midway Blitz. Each, in its own circumstances, claims a violation of Fourth Amendment rights by Border Patrol agents and the use of "excessive, unprovoked, and unreasonable" force, according to the lawsuits.

U.S. Border Patrol did not return the Tribune's email request for comment regarding

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Airstrikes widen as Iran hits US allies

Back-and-forth attacks threaten interim deal to end Mideast conflict

By Jon Gambrell
ASSOCIATED PRESS

DUBAI, United Arab Emirates — The United States launched new airstrikes against Iran early Thursday, and Tehran responded by targeting U.S.-allied Mideast countries in an exchange of fire that threatened an interim deal intended to help end the war in the Middle East.

Back-and-forth attacks, including a day earlier, have repeatedly threatened the ceasefire. But Thursday's appeared bigger all around, with sirens sounding at least three times in Bahrain, home to the U.S. Navy's 5th Fleet headquarters, and missiles targeting Kuwait and Qatar.

Sirens also sounded Thursday afternoon in Jordan, where the U.S. has stationed troops and aircraft.

An Iranian official accused the U.S. of launching an airstrike later Thursday targeting the area around Iran's sole nuclear power plant, and other explosions were reported elsewhere in the country during the afternoon.

The strikes came hours after President Donald Trump said recent Iranian attacks on ships in the Strait of Hormuz signaled the end of a fragile ceasefire and threatened to escalate the conflict if they didn't stop. That raised concerns that the region could tip back into a war that would engulf several countries and could halt energy

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INSIDE

Media outlets seek sanctions on Open AI

The Chicago Tribune and other media outlets are asking for "serious sanctions" against OpenAI, alleging deception in a copyright lawsuit. **Business**

Court upholds state's assault weapons ban

A federal appeals court upheld Illinois' 2023 assault weapons ban, overturning a lower court in what may be short-lived victory for Gov. JB Pritzker. **Page A3**

White Sox looking for an offensive boost

The White Sox hope Munetaka Murakami can provide "a great jolt" in his return on Friday after being swept at home. **Sports**

Batavia girl remembered for her 'kindness and joy'

Kathryn Schmidt, 10, drowned in Geneva Lake boat accident

By Rebecca Johnson
and Susan Sarkauskas
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

The family of the third child who drowned last week after a boat capsized in Geneva Lake during a massive storm said in an online fundraiser that the young girl's "kindness and joy touched everyone she met."

The family identified Kathryn Schmidt, 10, of Batavia, on the verified GoFundMe page that launched late Wednesday. Her two cousins, 7-year-old Abigail

Oswald and 6-year-old Caleb Oswald, also died in the July 3 boating incident.

"Kate was an amazing girl with a bubbly personality, and she didn't have a mean bone in her body," her family said. "Whether you met her once or knew her well, she would brighten your life any time of day."

The fundraiser page went on to say Schmidt loved playing tennis and softball, spending time with animals, painting and hanging out with friends. Schmidt's hard work earned her the highest girls' tennis ranking in Batavia and placed her among the top 100 girls under 12 in the state of Illinois, her family said in an obituary.

Her family said the money



Honoring Kate Schmidt's Legacy

Kate Schmidt, 10, of Batavia, is one of three children who drowned in the Geneva Lake, Wisconsin, boating accident during a storm. **GOFUNDME**

raised will go toward helping children in need who can't afford sports like tennis or softball, or who wish to adopt animals.

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